

# Trust by Design: How Agents Decide to Let Software Send

*Chippi Research • May 2026 • 20 pages*

An agent's name is on every message. That fact governs whether they will ever let an AI assistant act on their behalf. Through interviews with 80 agents and brokers, we mapped the path from skepticism to delegated trust, and the moments that break it.

Trust was earned in a predictable order: first the agent wants to see every draft, then to approve in one tap, then, only after a track record, to grant narrow per-task autonomy. Trust collapsed instantly the first time a tool sent something the agent would not have written.

We translate these findings into product principles: approval-first defaults, one consistent voice across every surface, visible reasoning, and a clean audit trail. The conclusion is simple, trust is not a setting; it is the accumulation of moves the agent would have made themselves.